

Foreword

into a prospering state, but he did not live to achieve this aim, due to his untimely death in 1937, at the age of forty-four. He did, however, write a faceted sketch on this theme, here entitled 'Tell Me, Bella', in which the narrator and his companion, Setrak, return to Armenia from America as volunteers and upon revisiting the latter's home town find it deserted except for the handful who had fled to the mountains and caves during the massacres. This story reflects something of the background of the life and events during the period of Armenian history in the first quarter of this century, as do the remaining stories in the present volume: hence the title of the book.

M. K.

Pale-blue Flowers

THERE WERE BARELY a few people at her funeral: her sister, Tourvanda Korro; Tourvanda Korro's husband, Krikor-the-Saddler; her husband's brother, Simon; two neighbours with their wives; the priest and the beadle—the priest had arranged for the clerk not to come, so that the money they would receive would be divided between two, instead of three. Her husband had lain in the cemetery for a year and had been waiting for her.

They buried Sara beside her husband.

Before they left the cemetery, the priest demanded his reward, and once outside the fence, they all separated.

Krikor-the-Saddler said to his wife:

'Well, wife, I had better go to the shop.'

At the house of mourning, the only person waiting for Tourvanda Korro was the orphaned five-year-old Torrig.

When earlier, with tearful eyes, her black shawl over her head, and one hand on the coffin, Tourvanda Korro was leaving the house, she remembered Torrig. She left the coffin, went inside, opened the cupboard, took a piece of dry bread, gave it to the boy, sat him on the mattress, and said:

'Sit here, my little pet. I will be back soon.'

Torrigh took the bread and began to gnaw at it.

Tourvanda Korro caught up with the coffin.

And when she returned from the funeral, Torrig had nibbled away half the bread; with the remaining half he was playing a game with the kitten. The kitten gambolled about, nipped the piece of bread, while the boy tugged at it, freed it, and laughed.

Seeing that Torrig was totally unaware of the misfortune of being deprived of the most precious person on earth, Tourvanda Korro's heart sank again. The plaintive weeping at the burial arose once more in the blackened, miserable, tiny, and tottering cottage.

There was no one, absolutely no one in the whole world apart from Tourvanda Korro to look after the orphan. So that, without any decisions to be made, she picked up Torrig, wrapped him up in her black shawl, and took him to her own house. There she lit the fire immediately, heated some water, bathed the orphan,